Philosophy · Metaphysics of God · AQA A-level 7172

The Design Argument: Workbook

Use this workbook alongside the handout The Design argument for the existence of God. Work through each part after reading the matching section of the handout.

Name: _____

Class: _____ Teacher: _____

How to use this workbook

Each part matches a section of the handout. Read that section first, then do the tasks.

Tasks are short and numbered. You can stop at the end of any task and pick up again later.

If you have missed a lesson, start at the part you missed. Each part makes sense on its own.

Use the glossary (Part 09) whenever you meet a word you are not sure of.

Tick off each part in the checklist at the back when you finish it.

In this workbook

01. Getting started: key ideas
02. Hume's analogical version of the argument
03. Paley's watchmaker argument
04. Hume's seven objections
05. Paley responds
06. Evolution and the design argument
07. Swinburne's argument from temporal order
08. Evaluating the argument: building your essay
09. Glossary
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Part 01 Getting started: key ideas

Handout section: the opening paragraphs. The design argument says some things in nature look so well fitted to a purpose that the best explanation is an intelligent designer — God.

Task 1 · Sort the facts

1 Fill in the table using the handout.

Thinker	Key work	Date	One thing I know about their view
David Hume			
William Paley			
Richard Swinburne	(modern defence)	—	

Task 2 · A priori or a posteriori?

Key idea An a posteriori argument starts from experience of the world. An a priori argument works by reason alone.

2 Is the design argument a priori or a posteriori? Circle one, then explain how you know.

a priori / a posteriori

Task 3 · Spot the purpose

3 For each example, say what it is for (its function). Then tick whether it is made by humans or found in nature.

Object	What is it for?	Human-made?	Natural?
A watch			
An eye			
A house			
A hand			
A heart			

4 What do the human-made and the natural objects have in common? Why might this make someone think of a designer?

Part 02 Hume's analogical version of the argument

Handout section: David Hume. Hume sets out the argument (through the character Cleanthes) before he attacks it.

> *'Since the effects resemble each other, we are led to infer by all the rules of analogy that the causes are also alike…'*
>
> — Hume, Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion (1779), as quoted in the handout

Task 5 · Rebuild the argument

5 Fill the gaps to rebuild Hume's five steps. Use the word bank.

Word bank designed · God · similar · purpose · human design · intelligent

1. Things in nature seem to have a clear _____ and function, like objects of _____.
2. _____ effects have similar causes.
3. So the products of nature must, like human products, have been _____.
4. So the things in nature have an _____ designer.
5. This designer is _____.

Task 6 · What is an analogy?

6 In your own words, what is an analogy? Give one example of your own.

7 The handout compares a school to a holiday camp and to a prison. Which analogy is stronger, and why? What does this show about arguments from analogy?

Task 8 · Diagram it

8 Complete the diagram. Write in each box.

Human design		Nature
Effect: _____	is like →	Effect: _____
↑ caused by		↑ caused by
Cause: _____	so is like →	Cause: _____

9 Explain the design argument from analogy in no more than three sentences.

Part 03 Paley's watchmaker argument

Handout section: William Paley: The argument from design.

> *'Every indication of contrivance, every manifestation of design, which existed in the watch, exists in the works of nature…'*
>
> — Paley, Natural Theology (1802), as quoted in the handout

Task 10 · The stone and the watch

10 Complete the table to show why Paley treats the stone and the watch differently.

	The stone	The watch
How might it have come to be there?		
Does it show contrivance / purpose?		
What does Paley conclude?		

Task 11 · True or false?

11 Tick true or false. Correct each false statement underneath it.

Statement	True	False
Paley's argument is an argument from analogy, just like Hume's version.		
Paley uses 'inference to the best explanation'.		
For Paley, an infinite chain of watches producing watches would remove the need for a designer.		
Paley thinks natural objects are less complex than a watch.		
The best explanation is the one that explains the facts with the least complexity.		

Task 12 · Hume vs Paley

12 Compare the two versions. This difference matters: some of Hume's objections hit Hume's version but not Paley's.

	Hume's version	Paley's version
Type of reasoning		
What is compared?		
Key example		
Key question it asks		

13 In your own words, what is 'inference to the best explanation'? Why does it make Paley's argument harder to attack than an argument from analogy?

Part 04

Hume's seven objections

Handout section: Objections to the design argument. Hume gives seven objections. Work through them one at a time.

Task 14 · Objection organiser

14 For each objection, explain it in your own words and give the example from the handout. Rate how strong you think it is (1 = weak, 5 = strong).

Objection	In my own words	Example from handout	1–5
1. The analogy is weak			
2. Anthropomorphism			
3. Apparent design does not prove a designer (Epicurean hypothesis)			
4. One universe is not enough			
5. Dysteleology			
6. Do not assume more in the cause than the effect needs			
7. Belief in God is useless			

Task 15 · Match the quotation

15 Each line comes from a Hume quotation in the handout. Write the number of the objection it supports.

Line from the handout	Objection no.
'The dissimilarity is so striking, that the upmost you can pretend to is a guess…'	
'…nature may contain the source or spring of order originally, within itself…'	
'…pouring forth from her lap, without discernment or parental care, her maimed and abortive children'	
'If the cause be known only by the effect, we never ought to ascribe to it any qualities, beyond what are precisely requisite…'	
'…it is not sufficient surely, that we have ships and cities arise from human art and contrivance'	
'…we embrace a principle which is uncertain and useless.'	

Task 16 · Think it through

16 The Epicurean hypothesis: explain how finite matter in infinite time could produce order without a designer.

17 Smoke and fire: why can we infer fire from smoke, but not (says Hume) a designer from the universe?

18 Zeuxis the painter: what does this example show about what we can know of a designer from the world?

19 Which of Hume's objections do not work against Paley? Explain why. (Hint: look back at Task 12.)

Part 05 Paley responds

Handout section: Paley responds. Paley gives three replies. Link each one to the Hume objection it answers.

Task 20 · Reply tracker

Paley's reply	Which Hume objection(s) does it answer?	Does it succeed? Why?
1. We could infer a designer even if we had never seen a watch made.		
2. A designer fits better with Ockham's razor.		
3. Minor imperfections do not disprove design.		

Key idea Ockham's razor: do not multiply entities beyond necessity — prefer the simpler explanation.

21 Paley says a watch that 'sometimes went wrong' still shows design. Is this a good reply to dysteleology? Give one point for and one against.

For:

Against:

Part 06 Evolution and the design argument

Handout section: Evolution. Neither Hume nor Paley knew of Darwin's theory of evolution by natural selection.

Task 22 · Explain the challenge

22 Put these in order (1–4) to explain natural selection.

Step	Order
Features that help survival become common; others fade out.	
Animals reproduce and pass on their features.	
Over millions of years, animals look 'designed' for their environment.	
Some animals have features that help them survive better than others.	

23 Which of Hume's objections does evolution make stronger? Explain.

24 The handout says evolution makes a new question 'pressing'. What is that question, and why does it lead to Swinburne?

Part 07 Swinburne's argument from temporal order

Handout section: Swinburne's Design Argument. Swinburne moves from the parts of nature to the regular patterns of nature over time — the laws of nature.

Key idea AQA's 2023 mark scheme notes Swinburne's distinction between 'spatial order' (regularities of copresence) and 'temporal order' (regularities of succession). Swinburne builds on temporal order.

Task 25 · Spatial or temporal?

25 Sort each example: spatial order (parts arranged together) or temporal order (a regular pattern over time)? Tick one.

Example	Spatial	Temporal
The parts of an eye fitting together		
Planets moving in regular orbits		
The parts of a watch		
Objects falling according to the law of gravity		
A student arriving at school at the same time each day		
The notes of a song sung in sequence		

25b Pick one example you sorted. Explain why it is spatial or temporal order.

Task 26 · The process of elimination

26 Complete the flow of Swinburne's argument.

Step	Fill in
There are regular patterns in nature. Example:	
There are only two kinds of explanation for patterns:	1. 2.
The laws of nature cannot explain themselves, because...	
So the best explanation is...	

> *'If their operation is to receive an explanation and not merely to be left as a brute fact, that explanation must be due to the rational choice of a free agent.'*
>
> — Swinburne, as quoted in the handout

27 What is a 'brute fact'? Why does Swinburne refuse to leave the laws of nature as one?

Task 28 · Swinburne answers Hume

28 Use the handout to show how Swinburne responds.

Hume's challenge	Swinburne's response
The designer need not be infinite or perfect.	
The designer could be many gods.	
The designer could have died.	
We should not jump to assumptions about the cause of the world.	

Part 08 Evaluating the argument: building your essay

Handout section: Conclusion. Now turn your knowledge into an argument. A good essay takes a clear line from the start and defends it.

Task 29 · Where do you stand?

29 Mark an X on the line to show how successful you think the design argument is.

Fails completely ●——————————● Proves God exists

30 Explain your choice in one sentence. This is your thesis — your answer to the question.

Task 31 · Argument ladder

Build one paragraph of your essay. Each step answers the step before it.

Step	Write here
Point: a version of the argument (e.g. Paley's)	
Objection: the strongest problem for it	
Response: how a defender replies	
Weigh it up: does the reply work? Why?	
Link back: what this shows about your thesis	

32 The handout concludes that the argument shows God is a 'live possibility' but is not a 'knock down proof'. Do you agree? Give a reason.

Part 09 Glossary

Key terms from the handout. Use these when you write your answers.

Term	Meaning
A posteriori	Known through experience of the world. The design argument is a posteriori.
A priori	Known through reason alone, without experience.
Analogy	Comparing two things that share a similar structure or function to help explain one of them.
Anthropomorphism	Describing God in human terms. Hume says the design argument makes God too much like a human designer.
Artificer	A skilled maker or craftsperson. Paley's word for the watch's designer.
Brute fact	A fact that has no further explanation; it simply is.
Constant conjunction	Two things always being observed together (e.g. smoke and fire), which lets us infer one from the other.
Contrivance	Something skilfully made to serve a purpose.
Design argument	An argument that the order or purpose in nature is best explained by an intelligent designer, God. Also called the teleological argument.
Dysteleology	Poor or pointless design in nature (e.g. the appendix), which counts against a perfect designer.
Epicurean hypothesis	Hume's suggestion that finite matter moving over infinite time could produce order by chance.
Inference to the best explanation	Accepting the explanation that best makes sense of the facts with the least complexity. Paley's method.
Mitigated sceptic	Someone who suspends judgement, neither affirming nor denying (Hume on God).
Natural selection	Darwin's theory: features that help survival are passed on, so living things come to look designed.
Ockham's razor	The principle that the simplest explanation, with the fewest entities, is best.
Spatial order	Order in how parts are arranged together (e.g. the parts of an eye). Swinburne: 'regularities of copresence'.
Temporal order	Regular patterns over time, such as the laws of nature. Swinburne: 'regularities of succession'.
Teleology	From Greek telos, 'end' or 'purpose': the study of purpose in nature.

My own key terms

Add any other words you meet, with their meanings.

Part 10 AQA past exam questions

These are real questions from AQA A-level Philosophy Paper 2 (7172/2), Section A: Metaphysics of God. Answer them in exam conditions when you are ready.

Key idea Mark guide: 3-mark questions want a precise, accurate definition. 5-mark questions want a clear explanation with no irrelevant material. 25-mark questions want a clear thesis, sustained argument and a reasoned judgement.

June 2023 · Question 01

Q What does Swinburne mean by 'temporal order/regularity' in his design argument? [3 marks]

Examiner tip (from the AQA 2023 mark scheme)

Top answers mention the 'temporal' dimension of the order and explain it using a feature of Swinburne's argument, such as 'regularities of succession' or the laws of nature.

Do not confuse temporal order with spatial order. You do not have to mention God, but if you do, describe Swinburne's argument accurately.

June 2022 · Question 02

Q Explain the design argument from analogy as presented by Hume. [5 marks]

June 2019 · Question 05

Q How successful is the design argument for the existence of God? [25 marks]

Plan first. Use your argument ladder from Part 08.

Plan	Notes
My thesis	
Paragraph 1	
Paragraph 2	
Paragraph 3	
Conclusion / judgement	

Note for students

Question wording is taken from AQA's published mark schemes for June 2019, June 2022 and June 2023. Check past papers for other years with your teacher.

Part 11 Progress checklist

Tick when you finish each part. Then rate your confidence: R = not yet, A = getting there, G = confident.

Part	Done ✓	R / A / G
01. Getting started: key ideas		
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One thing I understand well:

One thing I need to go over again: